

# Social media bubbles

Social media platforms allow us to see what we want to see, and filter out the stuff we don't. But it's not just the technology that does it: it's part of our psychology, too.

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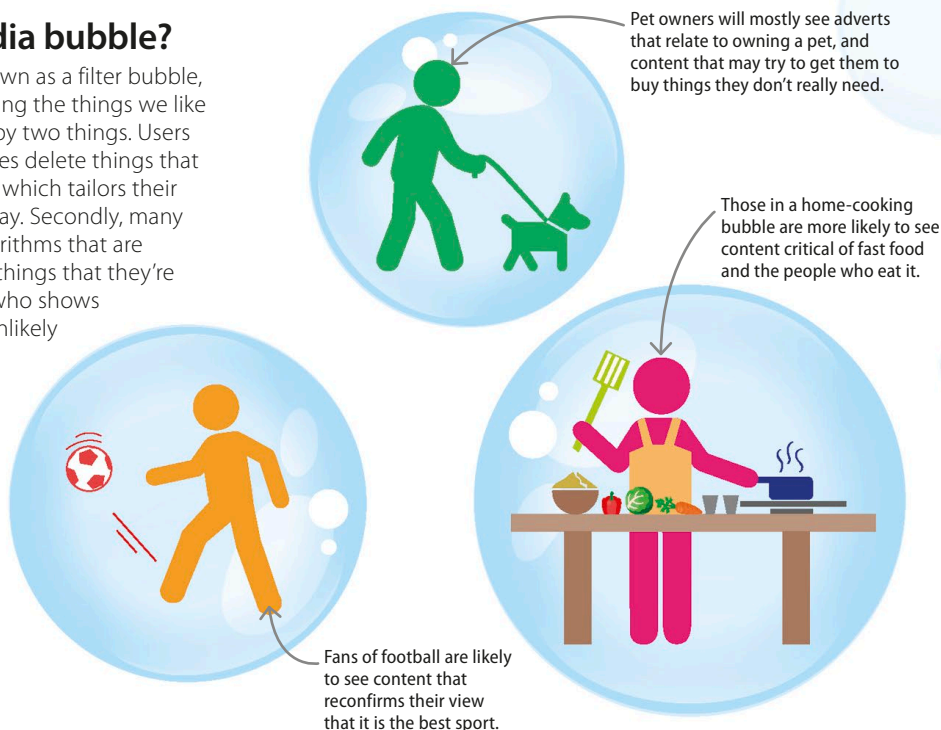
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## What is a social media bubble?

A social media bubble, also known as a filter bubble, is the phenomenon of only seeing the things we like on social media. This is caused by two things. Users can block, ignore, and sometimes delete things that they don't agree with or dislike, which tailors their social media feed in a certain way. Secondly, many social media platforms use algorithms that are geared towards showing users things that they're likely to want to see. A person who shows support for a political party is unlikely to see anything that is critical of that party or point of view.

### ▷ Bubbles

If all people see on social media are things that they like and agree with, they run the risk of being isolated from other groups and perhaps gradually losing the ability to understand others.



## Why we like who we like

We are drawn to people who are similar to us: perhaps they look like us, or they dress like us. They may have similar backgrounds to us or have had similar experiences. These become the foundations for friendships because we can relate to these people and what they think. While this is a positive thing, it can limit how much we understand those that are not like us.

### ▷ Trust

We are more likely to trust information that comes from people we trust – even if they don't have any relevant expertise in the topic!



## LINGO

### Useful terms

**Strong ties:** people we connect to who are part of our social circle, and with whom we have lots of direct or indirect connections.

**Weak ties:** people we connect to by chance or accidentally, with whom we have few or no other connections.

**Confirmation bias:** being more likely to like or believe something that confirms your existing beliefs.